Hanoi Egg Coffee

Pocket Recipe · no phin or condensed milk needed

1 cup · 10 minutes. Strong hot coffee topped with a thick, sweet whipped egg-yolk foam: the drink Hanoi has served since the 1940s, when fresh milk was scarce.

Ingredients

- **2 fresh egg yolks** (pasteurized if possible)
- **2 tbsp sweetened condensed milk** (or a swap, page 2)
- **1 tsp sugar** (optional)
- **60 ml (¼ cup) very strong hot coffee**, dark roast; Vietnamese robusta is most authentic
- **Tools:** deep bowl, electric hand mixer or milk frother (or a whisk), small cup

Method

1. **Brew the coffee first** and keep it hot.
2. **Separate the eggs.** Only yolks: a little white makes the foam runny.
3. **Add sweetness:** condensed milk (or swap) and sugar.
4. **Whisk until it ribbons:** 3–5 min with a mixer or frother, 8–10 min by hand. Pale, doubled, falls in thick ribbons.
5. **Warm the cup** with hot water, then pour in the coffee.
6. **Spoon the foam on top** so it floats.
7. **Hanoi style:** stand the cup in a bowl of hot water. Eat the foam first, then stir and sip.

Shopping List

Item	Note
Eggs	Pasteurized if you can find them
Sweetened condensed milk	Or sugar + heavy cream, mascarpone, honey
Dark roast coffee	Vietnamese robusta, or an Italian espresso roast
Sugar	Optional, to taste
Milk frother	Cheap, fast, and makes the best foam

No Phin? Brew 60 ml Strong Coffee

You have	How to brew
Moka pot	Closest to phin strength. Use the first 60 ml.
Espresso machine	A double shot (about 60 ml).
AeroPress	Fine grind, 18 g coffee, 80 ml water, 1 min, press.
French press	Double your usual coffee, steep 4–5 min.
Instant coffee	2 heaped tsp in 60 ml just-boiled water.
Pour-over / drip	Double the coffee-to-water ratio, brew slowly.

No Condensed Milk? Swaps for 2 Yolks

Swap	Result
2 tbsp sugar + 1 tbsp heavy cream	Lighter, silky foam. Easiest swap.
Homemade condensed milk: simmer 250 ml milk + 80 g sugar until halved (~30 min), cool	Closest to the real taste. Keeps 1 week in the fridge.
1 tbsp mascarpone + 1½ tbsp sugar	Rich, tiramisu-like.
1½ tbsp honey or maple syrup	Thinner foam, floral. Whisk longer.
Sweetened condensed coconut milk	Dairy-free, gentle coconut note.

Quick Fixes

- **Foam too runny?** Keep whisking, or add 1 tsp more condensed milk or sugar.
- **Tastes eggy?** It needs more whisking or more sweetness.
- **Iced version:** coffee over ice, foam on top, taste the foam before stirring.
- **Raw egg note:** use the freshest (ideally pasteurized) eggs. Not for pregnant women, young children, older adults or anyone with a weakened immune system.

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